NAPOLEONIC EUROPE

While Napoleon's armies swept all before them in mainland Europe, the war at sea was a different matter. The Royal Navy blockaded the major ports such as Toulon and Brest, restricting trade and keeping the French from bringing their own naval forces out to do battle. On the few occasions they succeeded, they were defeated.

KEY

- French territory ruled directly from Paris 1812
- Dependent states 1812
- Britain and British occupied territories
- British naval blockade
- British victory
- British defeat
- Inconclusive battle
- Movement of British fleet
- Movement of French fleet



practice sharpened up the navy. He was most demanding of his officers, believing that captains should lead by example to form well-drilled, motivated crews.

Nelson was in a sense a product of the Jervis school of leadership, forming his officers into a "band of brothers" who could be trusted to take the initiative in battle. Nelson himself sometimes went further, acting directly counter to orders. This earned him official disapproval, but in general officers were rewarded for showing offensive spirit. Apart from victories in battle, the British blockade of French ports was an astonishing feat of seamanship and organization. The French often fought well, but they were up against a navy rising to an unprecedented dominance of the world's oceans.

Battle of Copenhagen
In 1801 a fleet under Admiral Sir Hyde Parker with Nelson as his second-in-command was sent to Copenhagen to deal with the threat posed to Britain by the Russian-led League of Armed Neutrality. Nelson disobeyed Parker's orders, opening fire on the Danish fleet, sinking three ships and capturing 12.

